

Define Success

Agree what a good solution must achieve up front

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Define Success is the practice of agreeing, before building, the concrete criteria and metrics by which a solution will be judged — user, business and feasibility outcomes. It creates a shared target so teams can later tell whether they have actually succeeded.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A design-toolbox practice (Lewrick, Link and Leifer) aligned with outcome-based goal-setting such as OKRs.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Without agreed success criteria, teams argue endlessly about whether an idea 'worked'. Defining success up front aligns effort and enables honest evaluation.

HOW IT IS USED

Co-create measurable success criteria across desirability, viability and feasibility, revisit them at each stage, and test outcomes against them.

WHEN IT IS USED

Framing and planning stages, and as the yardstick for testing and implementation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Product leaders, teams and sponsors.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It installs **outcome discipline** in a creative process, ensuring novelty is judged against real value, not taste.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

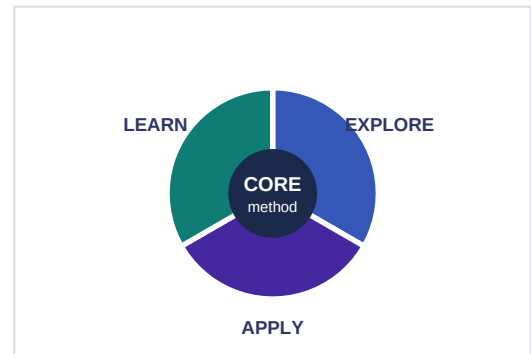


Figure 1. Define Success framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Implementation Roadmap *Slibrary 10*

A/B Testing *Slibrary 9*

Critical Items Diagram *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

Doerr, J. (2018) *Measure What Matters*. New York: Portfolio/Penguin.